Cybersecurity Awareness Guide for Students and Early-Career Staff

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Purpose

This guide helps university students and early-career staff recognise common online scams, respond safely, and report them. It is written for non-technical readers.

Why this matters

Most cyberattacks on students and new employees start with a message, not with hacking. Attackers trick people into clicking, replying or sharing a password, because that is easier than breaking into a system. This guide shows how to spot those tricks and what to do when one reaches you.

Phishing and social engineering

Phishing is a fake email, SMS, call or website that pretends to be a trusted sender to steal logins, money or personal data. **Social engineering** is the wider habit behind it: manipulating emotions such as fear, curiosity, trust or greed so that a person bypasses their own caution.

Common forms are email phishing, SMS phishing (smishing), voice calls (vishing), fake job or internship offers, and fake scholarship or prize messages. Students are targeted often because they use many new accounts and respond quickly to anything that looks official.

Suspicious links, attachments, impersonation and urgency

- **Links:** A link's visible text can differ from its real destination. Hover (or long-press on a phone) to preview the address before opening, or type the website address yourself.
- **Attachments:** Unexpected files, especially .zip, .exe, .html or Office files that ask you to "enable macros", can install malware.

- **Impersonation:** Attackers copy the name, logo and tone of a professor, HR manager, bank or well-known company. A familiar name does not prove the sender is real.
- **Urgency tactics:** Phrases such as "act within 2 hours" or "account will be blocked" are designed to stop you from thinking. Real organisations rarely demand instant action over email.

Six clear warning signs

1. **Mismatched sender:** The display name looks right, but the address is odd, such as support@paypa1-secure.com instead of the real domain.
2. **Urgent or threatening language:** Deadlines, penalties or "final warning" messages push you to act before checking.
3. **Request for credentials, OTP or payment:** No genuine bank, university or company asks for your password or OTP by email, SMS or call.
4. **Unexpected link or attachment:** You were not expecting the message, and it asks you to click, download or scan a QR code.
5. **Generic greeting and poor language:** "Dear user" or "Dear customer", plus spelling mistakes or odd formatting.
6. **Too good to be true:** Free prizes, guaranteed jobs, or an internship that asks you to pay a registration fee.

Fictional examples and how to respond

Scenario (fictional)	Red flags	How to respond
Email from "Campus IT Helpdesk" saying your mailbox is full and will be deleted in 3 hours. Link: campus-mail-verify.example.com	Urgency, link not on the official university domain, generic greeting	Do not click. Open the university portal by typing its address, and forward the email to the IT team
WhatsApp message from an unknown number: "Congratulations, you won a laptop. Pay Rs 499 delivery charge to claim."	Unexpected prize, request for payment, unknown sender	Do not pay or reply. Block the number and report it

Scenario (fictional)	Red flags	How to respond
Email from "HR Manager" offering an internship, attaching "Offer_Letter.zip" and asking for a copy of your ID	Unrequested job offer, zipped attachment, request for personal documents	Do not open the file. Check the company's official website and contact HR through the listed number

A simple rule for every case: **stop, check, report.** Stop before clicking, check the sender through a separate trusted channel, and report anything suspicious.

What to do if you clicked

Act quickly and calmly; speed limits the damage.

1. **Disconnect:** Turn off Wi-Fi or mobile data if you downloaded a file or entered details.
2. **Change passwords:** Change the password of any account you entered, from a different, safe device. Do the same for any other account that uses that password.
3. **Enable multi-factor authentication** on your email, banking and social accounts.
4. **Scan your device** with updated antivirus or your phone's built-in security tool.
5. **Check accounts:** Look for unknown logins, forwarding rules, or transactions. If money or card details are involved, call your bank immediately and block the card.
6. **Report it** (see next section) and tell your IT team or manager. Reporting quickly is never a mistake.

Safe reporting

- **Inside your organisation:** Forward the message to your university IT team or company security contact, then delete it.
- **Email provider:** Use "Report phishing" in Gmail or Outlook so the sender can be blocked.
- **In India:** Report cybercrime at cybercrime.gov.in or call the national helpline **1930** immediately for financial fraud. Phishing incidents can also be reported to CERT-In.
- **Keep evidence:** Take screenshots and save the sender address, but do not reply or click again.

Conclusion

Most attacks succeed because a person acts in a hurry. Slowing down, verifying the sender through a separate channel, and reporting early stop the majority of phishing attempts. Share this guide with classmates and colleagues, because awareness protects everyone in a group.

References

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